Week 6: Business Writing and Business Letters

NPTEL Soft Skills · Prof. Binod Mishra · Lectures 26–30

Contents

1. Lecture 26: Types of Business Writing Part II
2. Lecture 27: Business Letters
3. Lecture 28: Business Letters: Format & Style
4. Lecture 29: Types of Business Letters Part I
5. Lecture 30: Types of Business Letters Part II

Lecture 26: Types of Business Writing Part II

Week 6 · Course book PDF pages 411–428 (printed pages 410–427)

Learning objectives

- Draft a notice, agenda and minutes of a meeting with correct format and language.
- Write professional e-mails following netiquette.
- Differentiate research paper types: journal paper, conference paper, review article, thesis, term paper, technical paper.
- Plan a research paper: title, literature review, outline, statement of purpose, revision, references.

Important definitions

NOTICE

Pre-information about a meeting stating the issuer, venue, date, time and agenda; sent several days in advance.

AGENDA

From *agendum*: the list of items to be discussed in a meeting, prepared with the chairman; usually attached to the notice.

MINUTES

A sequential written record of the happenings in a meeting, prepared by the secretary in consultation with the chairman, in the past tense.

NOTE OF DISSENT

A written disagreement a member may submit when he does not agree with the minutes or decisions.

RESEARCH PAPER

A document presenting a new finding or analysis, supported by evidence and references.

REVIEW ARTICLE

An article that examines and evaluates a new book, film or development in a field.

Core concepts

Notice of a meeting

- Organisation name at top centre; heading **NOTICE**.
- State the number of the meeting (e.g. 10th meeting), body (board of directors / executive committee), date, day, time, venue and mention that the agenda is attached.
- Issue **well in advance (4–5 days)** unless urgent.
- Signed by the secretary (hard copy).

Agenda

- Items numbered as 5.1, 5.2 (meeting number.item number).
- **First item:** confirmation of the minutes of the previous meeting.
- **Last item:** any other matter with the permission of the chair.
- Prepared with the chairman; not attached for urgent or secret meetings.

Minutes

- Written by the secretary after the meeting (a day or two later), finalised with the chairman and circulated.
- Heading: organisation, **Minutes of the Nth meeting**, date and venue; chairman first, then members present; absentees listed after the secretary.
- Language: simple, specific, **past tense**, often passive (“was discussed”).
- Items follow the agenda sequence: 10.1 confirmation of minutes, 10.2 chairman’s report, 10.3 provision of laptops for office staff, … any other matter (canteen) … “The meeting ended with a vote of thanks to the chair.”
- Secretary signs, chairman signs on the left, with date.
- Not everything is recorded (off-the-record remarks); minutes serve as a record for future reference.
- An e-mail is only a medium; minutes are authentic when signed.

E-mail etiquette

- Use proper salutation for official mail; keep it short and specific; no sarcasm.
- **Avoid capital letters** (they are like shouting); use correct punctuation.
- Limit cc to those concerned (information load).
- Keep the signature line brief; check that the attachment is really attached.
- Avoid long emotional e-mails; remember that e-mails can be official records.

Research papers

- Organisations use R&D and incubation centres.

- Types: **technical paper**, **conference paper** (presented to peers), **journal paper** (for publication), **review article**, thesis, term paper.
- Steps: select a **specific title** → literature review in libraries → **outline** → **statement of purpose** → analysis and findings → conclusion → **revision** (language, grammar, addition, deletion) → bibliography/references.
- Title capitalisation: main words only, not prepositions or connectives.
- Examples: “Importance of soft skills at workplace”; “Role of media in women empowerment”.

Types, classifications and characteristics

Types of research writing

Type	Purpose
Technical paper	Detailed technical content, jargon allowed
Conference paper	Presented to peers for feedback
Journal paper	Submitted for publication per journal style
Review article	Evaluate a new book, film or work
Thesis / term paper	Academic requirement

Examples and applications

EXAMPLE

Notice of the 10th meeting of the board with agenda attached.

EXAMPLE

Minutes 10.1 – confirmation of previous minutes; 10.2 chairman’s report; any other matter – canteen arrangement.

EXAMPLE

E-mail sent with the attachment missing.

Comparison tables

Notice versus agenda versus minutes

Document	Time	Content
Notice	Before meeting	Date, time, venue, issuer
Agenda	Before meeting	List of items to discuss
Minutes	After meeting	Record of what happened (past tense)

Important facts for MCQ revision

EXAM TIP

- Notice is pre-information of a meeting.
- First agenda item: confirmation of previous minutes.
- Last agenda item: any other matter with the permission of the chair.
- Minutes are written in the past tense by the secretary.
- Item numbering such as 5.1 means meeting 5, item 1.
- Capitals in e-mail are like shouting.
- Agenda comes from agendum.
- Revision is the best antidote before sending a paper.
- Absentees are listed in minutes.

QUIZ-RELATED CONCEPTS (QUIZ PDF PAGE REFERENCES)

Question	Quiz PDF page	Concept tested	Type
W5 Q13	p.21	Internal business documents	MSQ
W6 Q6	p.22	Research paper	MCQ
W6 Q8	p.23	Minutes of a meeting	MCQ
W6 Q13	p.24	E-mail etiquette	MSQ
W6 Q14	p.24	Meeting documentation	MSQ

Full question text and answers: Quiz analysis.

Summary

A meeting is documented through a notice (issued days ahead with date, time, venue and agenda), an agenda (numbered items beginning with confirmation of previous minutes and ending with any other matter) and minutes (a signed, past-tense, sequential record). E-mails need brevity, courtesy and care with cc, capitals and attachments. Research papers require a specific title, literature review, outline, statement of purpose, revision and references.

Practice questions

Q1 MCQ The first item in the agenda is:

A. Any other matter

B. Confirmation of the minutes of the previous meeting

C. Vote of thanks

D. Chairman’s speech

> **Answer:** B
> **Why:** It is always the first item.

Q2 (MCQ) Minutes are written in the:

A. Future tense

B. Past tense

C. Present tense

D. Imperative

> **Answer:** B
> **Why:** They record what happened.

Q3 (MSQ) Which are e-mail do's?

A. Avoid capitals

B. Check attachments

C. Send to everyone through cc

D. Keep it brief

> **Answer:** A, B, D
> **Why:** Limit cc.

Q4 (T/F) A notice should be issued only a day before a routine meeting.

> **Answer:** False
> **Why:** Give 4–5 days unless urgent.

Q5 (Fill) Item '10.3' means the _____ item of the 10th meeting.

> **Answer:** third
> **Why:** Meeting number then item number.

Q6 (Short) What is a note of dissent?

> **Answer:** A written statement by a member who disagrees with a decision or the minutes.
> **Why:** It is recorded with the minutes.

Revision checklist

☐ I can draft a notice.

☐ I know agenda rules.

☐ I can write minutes in the right tense.

☐ I know e-mail etiquette.

☐ I know research paper steps.

Lecture 27: Business Letters

Week 6 · Course book PDF pages 429–449 (printed pages 428–448)

Learning objectives

- Explain the functions of business letters and how they differ from personal letters.
- List the ten parts of a business letter and the rules for each.
- State the correct salutation, closing and signature conventions.
- Recall Lord Chesterfield's advice on politeness.

Important definitions

BUSINESS LETTER

A formal written communication between an organisation and a customer, firm or individual for business purposes: direct, neutral in tone, simple in language, kept as record.

LETTERHEAD

The printed heading with organisation name, logo, address, telephone, fax and website.

INSIDE ADDRESS

The address of the recipient, written accurately with title and full name.

SUBJECT LINE

A clear one-line statement of what the letter is about.

COMPLIMENTARY CLOSE

The polite closing phrase such as 'Yours faithfully' or 'Yours sincerely'.

IDENTIFICATION MARKS

Initials of the dictator and the typist, e.g. BM/LKI.

ENCLOSURES

Attached documents; the number of pages is stated in brackets.

Core concepts

Why business letters still matter

- Maintain rapport with customers, clients and shareholders; speed up business.

- Serve as **record** for future reference and quasi-MOU (memorandum of understanding) of the dealings.
- Promote products, get feedback, expand business beyond a region.
- The writer represents the organisation; reveals personality and ability; employers want written skills.
- Horace Walpole's lady: “I write to you because I have nothing to do; I finish my letter because I have nothing to say.”

Business versus personal letters

- **Tone:** business letters are neutral, formal, direct, cordial; no sarcasm or emotion.
- **Content:** only business; personal letters (Charles Lamb, Thomas Gray, Carlyle, Robert Lynd, A. G. Gardiner, Lord Chesterfield) can talk about weather and family.
- **Language:** simple; no sesquipedalian (long) words or long sentences.
- Time is a commodity; come to the point at once.

Ten parts of a business letter

1. **Letterhead** – follow your organisation’s style (centre, left or right).
2. **Date line** – month first (March 10, 2017) or numeric; follow organisation practice.
3. **Reference** – both ‘Our ref.’ and ‘Your ref.’.
4. **Inside address** – full, accurate; use Shri/Dr/Mr/Ms; if name unknown write designation.
5. **Subject line**
6. **Salutation** – ‘Dear Sir/Madam’ (do not drop ‘Dear’); comma optional in full block.
7. **Body** – usually 3 paragraphs: opening (direct), discussion/details, closing.
8. **Complimentary close** – Yours faithfully/sincerely (no apostrophe in ‘Yours’).
9. **Signature line** – typed name in brackets; leave two lines gap for signature; ‘for’ when writing on behalf.
10. **Enclosures** (and identification marks) – state number of pages; e.g. cheque, receipt, order copy.

Closing lines

- Avoid participial endings such as “Waiting to see you” or “Hoping to get your response”.
- Use complete sentences: “I look forward to receiving your answer soon.”, “I hope to hear from you soon.”
- Yours truly / yours cordially are less common; a student may write ‘yours obediently’. Yours faithfully (unknown name) or yours sincerely are safest.

Politeness

Lord Chesterfield: politeness is as much concerned in answering letters within a reasonable time as in returning a bow immediately. Letters are an exchange of goodwill and build relationships.

Types, classifications and characteristics

Ten parts of a business letter

No.	Part	Key point
1	Letterhead	Name, logo, address, phone, fax, website
2	Date	Month first or numeric per organisation
3	Reference	Our and your reference
4	Inside address	Accurate name and address
5	Subject line	Clear topic
6	Salutation	Dear Sir/Madam
7	Body	Three paragraphs
8	Complimentary close	Yours faithfully/sincerely
9	Signature line	Name typed, space for signature
10	Enclosures	List, with number of pages

Theories, principles, models and contributors

POLITENESS IN LETTERS — LORD CHESTERFIELD

Answer letters within a reasonable time.

Examples and applications

EXAMPLE

Subject lines: “Regarding replacement of solar panel batteries”; “Transfer of my savings account”; “Regarding the status of my article”.

EXAMPLE

Inside address: Shri Rajkumar Bhatt, 25 Winter Mayor Cottage, Summer Hills, Shimla, Himachal Pradesh.

EXAMPLE

Identification marks BM/LKI.

Comparison tables

Business versus personal letter

Point	Business	Personal
Tone	Formal, neutral, cordial	Informal, emotional
Content	Only business	Family, weather, feelings
Format	Fixed ten parts	Free
Record value	High	Low

Important facts for MCQ revision

EXAM TIP

- A business letter has at least ten parts.
- Use ‘Dear Sir/Madam’.
- Yours faithfully / sincerely; no apostrophe after ‘Yours’.
- Reference includes ‘our reference’ and ‘your reference’.
- Body usually has three paragraphs.
- Identification marks: dictator’s and typist’s initials.
- Enclosures with number of pages.
- Lord Chesterfield on prompt reply.
- Follow the organisation’s letterhead and date style.

QUIZ-RELATED CONCEPTS (QUIZ PDF PAGE REFERENCES)

Question	Quiz PDF page	Concept tested	Type
W6 Q2	p.22	Closing of business letters	Fill-in-the-blank
W6 Q4	p.22	Tone of business letters	Fill-in-the-blank

Full question text and answers: Quiz analysis.

Summary

Business letters keep organisations and customers in touch, serve as records and reveal the writer’s skill. They are formal, neutral and direct, unlike personal letters. The standard structure has ten parts – letterhead, date, reference, inside address, subject, salutation, body, complimentary close, signature and enclosures – and requires accuracy, courtesy and prompt replies.

Practice questions

Q1 (MCQ) A business letter has at least how many parts?

A. 5

B. 8

C. 10

D. 15

> **Answer:** C
> **Why:** Ten parts.

Q2 (MCQ) The safest complimentary close for a letter to an unnamed person is:

A. Yours faithfully

B. Love

C. Cheers

D. Bye

> **Answer:** A
> **Why:** Yours faithfully / sincerely.

Q3 (MSQ) Which belong to the structure of a business letter?

A. Subject line

B. Enclosures

C. Poem

D. Inside address

> **Answer:** A, B, D
> **Why:** There is no poem.

Q4 (T/F) A business letter may include weather and family news.

> **Answer:** False
> **Why:** It deals only with business.

Q5 (Fill) Both ‘our’ and ‘your’ _____ are written in a business letter.

> **Answer:** reference
> **Why:** To trace correspondence.

Q6 (Short) How should a business letter be closed?

> **Answer:** With a complete sentence such as ‘I look forward to hearing from you soon’, then ‘Yours faithfully/sincerely’.
> **Why:** Avoid ‘hoping to…’ endings.

Revision checklist

☐ I can list the ten parts.
☐ I know the date and reference conventions.
☐ I know the correct complimentary close.
☐ I can explain business vs personal letters.
☐ I recall Chesterfield.

Lecture 28: Business Letters: Format & Style

Week 6 · Course book PDF pages 450–466 (printed pages 449–465)

Learning objectives

- Describe the four letter formats: full block, modified block, semi-block (indented), simplified.
- State the punctuation rules (open punctuation) and placement of date, close and signature for each.
- Apply style rules: reader-friendly, you-approach, thank-you opening, positive language, active/passive voice, I versus we.
- Rewrite negative letter sentences positively.

Important definitions

FULL BLOCK FORMAT

All parts (date, address, salutation, subject, body, close, signature, enclosures) are aligned to the left margin; open punctuation; the most common format in organisations.

MODIFIED BLOCK FORMAT

Address, subject, salutation and body paragraphs on the left; date, complimentary close and signature between the centre and the right margin.

SEMI-BLOCK (INDENTED) FORMAT

Like modified block but paragraphs are indented.

SIMPLIFIED FORMAT

Used when the recipient’s name or gender is unknown: no salutation, no complimentary close; subject line and attention line; date and writer's name aligned on the right.

OPEN PUNCTUATION

No punctuation in the inside address, salutation and complimentary close; punctuation only in the body.

ATTENTION LINE

A line (in capitals) directing the letter to a particular person or post, e.g. ATTENTION: Finance Officer.

Core concepts

Four formats

1. **Full block** – everything on the left; no commas after date or address; double space between salutation and subject; typed name in brackets with gap for signature; designation below.
2. **Modified block** – date, close and signature between right margin and centre; body blocked; sometimes a colon after 'Dear Sir'.
3. **Semi-block** – same as modified, but **paragraphs indented**; date in the middle or right; inside address at left.
4. **Simplified** – no salutation or close; use subject and attention line; writer's name on right; like a memo; easy to type.

Always follow the practice of your organisation.

Salutation when gender is unknown

Write 'Dear' plus the first name (Dear Rahil, Dear Stella, Dear Stephanie).

Opening and closing

- Reply letters begin with **thanks** ("Thank you for your letter dated ..." / mention reference no.).
- Come straight to the point: "Please find enclosed...".
- Last line should be cordial, reinforcing goodwill (you-approach); mention enclosures.

Style of business letters

- **Reader-friendly, you-approach** – imagine receiving your own letter.
- **Courtesy** – thank-you note connects with earlier correspondence.
- **Consideration** – short, to the point; do not write in anger; **do not blame the reader**; avoid many negatives.
- **Be specific** – mention model, colour, design in orders; specific letters get quicker replies.
- **Simple and precise** words, natural tone.
- **I versus we:** use 'we' when representing the organisation; 'I' for personal informal tone.
- **Voice:** active for good news; passive for indirect or defensive messages.

Positive rewriting

- "If you do not pay on time, we will lose you as a customer" → "We appreciate timely payment to continue a relationship with our customers."
- "Your refrigerator's warranty has expired; service on payment" → "We welcome you as a valued customer; for goods out of warranty, service is available on payment."
- "We are glad we can now send your Xerox machine" → "Please find your new Xerox machine; we look forward to receiving orders from our valued customers."
- "Your application cannot be entertained; try next year" → "May we request you to submit a detailed resume with full educational details?"
- "We are not responsible for damages in transportation" → "Though we take care in quality control, things can go wrong in transit; we are always ready to serve you."

Types, classifications and characteristics

Letter formats compared

Feature	Full block	Modified block	Semi-block	Simplified
Date	Left	Right/centre-right	Right/middle	Right
Paragraphs	Blocked	Blocked	Indented	Blocked
Salutation	Yes	Yes (colon optional)	Yes	None
Close	Left	Right/centre-right	Right/centre-right	None
Subject line	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes (plus attention line)

Examples and applications

EXAMPLE

“Dear Rahil” when the gender is unknown.

EXAMPLE

Attention: Finance Officer / Registrar.

EXAMPLE

Subject: Regarding excursion (simplified format letter to the Regional Tourist Officer).

Comparison tables

Negative versus positive phrasing

Negative	Positive
Your warranty has expired	Service is available on payment for out-of-warranty goods
We will lose you as a customer	We appreciate timely payment
Your application cannot be entertained	We request a detailed resume

Important facts for MCQ revision

EXAM TIP

- Four formats: full block, modified block, semi-block, simplified.
- Full block: all on the left margin.
- Open punctuation: none in address, salutation and close.
- Semi-block: indented paragraphs.
- Simplified: no salutation or close; attention line.
- When gender unknown: Dear + first name.
- Begin replies with thanks and reference.
- Do not blame the reader.
- Use ‘we’ for the organisation.

QUIZ-RELATED CONCEPTS (QUIZ PDF PAGE REFERENCES)

Question	Quiz PDF page	Concept tested	Type
W6 Q1	p.22	Simplified letter format	Fill-in-the-blank

Full question text and answers: Quiz analysis.

Summary

Business letters are laid out in four formats – full block (all left), modified block (date, close and signature right of centre), semi-block (indented paragraphs) and simplified (no salutation or close, with subject and attention line). Whatever the format, style must be reader-friendly: thank, be specific and brief, avoid blame and negatives, use ‘we’ for the organisation and keep a positive, cordial tone.

Practice questions

Q1 MCQ In which format are paragraphs indented?

A. Full block
B. Semi-block
C. Simplified
D. None

> **Answer:** B
> **Why:** Semi-block has indented paragraphs.

Q2 (MCQ) Which format omits the salutation and complimentary close?

A. Full block

B. Modified block

C. Semi-block

D. Simplified

> **Answer:** D
> **Why:** It resembles a memo.

Q3 (MSQ) Which are features of full block?

A. All parts at left

B. Open punctuation

C. Indented paragraphs

D. Used widely

> **Answer:** A, B, D
> **Why:** Indentation belongs to semi-block.

Q4 (T/F) In style, one should blame the reader for the error.

> **Answer:** False
> **Why:** Do not blame the reader.

Q5 (Fill) If the recipient's gender is unknown, write ‘Dear’ followed by the _____ name.

> **Answer:** first
> **Why:** E.g. Dear Stella.

Q6 (Short) Rewrite: ‘Your application cannot be entertained.’

> **Answer:** May we request you to submit a detailed resume with complete educational details?
> **Why:** Positive wording.

Revision checklist

☐ I know the four formats.

☐ I know open punctuation.

☐ I can rewrite negatives positively.

☐ I know I vs we.

☐ I know when to use the simplified format.

Lecture 29: Types of Business Letters Part I

Week 6 · Course book PDF pages 467–485 (printed pages 466–484)

Learning objectives

- List the types of business letters.
- Write a sales letter using the AIDA technique.
- Draft letters of enquiry, responses to enquiries, order letters, credit letters and refusal letters.
- Apply Sir Ernest Gowers' advice on courtesy.

Important definitions

SALES LETTER

A letter written like an advertisement to promote a product and convert the reader into a customer.

AIDA

Attention, Interest, Desire, Action: the pattern for sales letters.

LETTER OF ENQUIRY

A letter seeking information about a product or service; main idea first, polite command ending in a period.

ORDER LETTER

A letter placing an order; specific, direct, lists items vertically and states the payment procedure.

CREDIT LETTER

A request to purchase on credit, supported by valid credit references.

REFUSAL LETTER

A letter declining a request without breaking goodwill; gives reasons and keeps hope.

Core concepts

Types of business letters

Sales letters, letters of enquiry, placing orders, letters of credit, collection letters, refusal letters, claim letters, adjustment letters and letters of recognition. All business letters are goodwill letters.

Sir Ernest Gowers' rule

- If he is rude, be specially courteous.

- If he is muddle-headed, be specially lucid.
- If he is pig-headed, be patient.
- If he is helpful, be appreciative.
- If he convicts you of a mistake, acknowledge it (with gratitude).

Planning any letter

Three As: **Analysis, Anticipation, Adaptation** – determine your purpose, anticipate the reader's reaction, adapt and organise carefully; proofread.

Sales letter and AIDA

- **Introduction (Attention):** striking statement, significant point, quotation, question, special appeal, central selling point.
- **Body (Interest and Desire):** trial offers, guarantees, free samples, brochures.
- **Close (Action):** positive call to action, e.g. “Send your order today and be the first in town to own our new television.”
- Avoid exaggeration (ethical limit) and negatives (“Do not miss…”).

Letter of enquiry and its reply

- **Enquiry:** main idea first; polite command ending in a period; appreciation at the end (“I appreciate this information, which will enable me to decide on 45 ACs.”); subject line should be clear.
- **Reply:** good news first; avoid dull openings (“Lying before me is your letter…”); begin “Please find the information you requested…”; answer all queries sequentially; use lists or bullets; enclose brochures/coupons to promote other products.
- Mixed messages: give good news first, place bad news before the end, close positively (e.g. accept the talk but propose the last week of March because of a conference in Sweden).

Order, credit and refusal letters

- **Order letter:** first line “Please send me 45 Hitachi window ACs”; be specific; list items vertically; mention payment procedure (cheque, banking); cordial conclusion.
- **Credit letter:** give sufficient valid credit references and offer additional information.
- **Refusal of credit:** thank the applicant; explain (company is new); welcome cash purchases; promise future credit arrangements; keep the customer.

Types, classifications and characteristics

AIDA in a sales letter

Letter	Stage	Technique
A	Attention	Striking opening, quotation, question
I	Interest	Explain features and benefits
D	Desire	Samples, guarantees, trial offers
A	Action	Prompt the reader to order

Theories, principles, models and contributors

COURTESY TOWARD CORRESPONDENTS — SIR ERNEST GOWERS

Be courteous to the rude, lucid to the muddle-headed, patient to the pig-headed, appreciative of the helpful and gracious when proved wrong.

AIDA PROCESS — ADVERTISING MODEL

Attention → Interest → Desire → Action.

Examples and applications

EXAMPLE

Insurance agent writes to promote another policy.

EXAMPLE

Enquiry about 25 geysers, 20 room heaters or 45 ACs.

EXAMPLE

Accepting a talk invitation while proposing the third week of March.

EXAMPLE

Credit refusal: company is new; pay cash now.

Comparison tables

Good news versus bad news placement

Position	Content
Beginning	Good news
Middle / before end	Bad news, softened
End	Positive, cordial close

Important facts for MCQ revision

EXAM TIP

- AIDA = Attention, Interest, Desire, Action.
- Three As of planning: analysis, anticipation, adaptation.
- Gowers: if he is rude, be specially courteous.
- Enquiry: main idea first; polite command ends with a period.
- Reply: good news first, avoid dull openings.
- Order letter: specific, vertical list, payment procedure.
- Credit letter needs valid credit references.
- Refusal letters must retain goodwill.

QUIZ-RELATED CONCEPTS (QUIZ PDF PAGE REFERENCES)

Question	Quiz PDF page	Concept tested	Type
W6 Q2	p.22	Closing of business letters	Fill-in-the-blank
W6 Q3	p.22	Subject line in business letters	Fill-in-the-blank
W6 Q7	p.23	Refusal letters	MCQ
W6 Q10	p.23	Parts of a business letter (sales letter)	MCQ

Full question text and answers: Quiz analysis.

Summary

Business letters include sales, enquiry, reply, order, credit, refusal, collection, claim, adjustment and recognition letters. Sales letters follow AIDA and avoid exaggeration and negatives. Enquiries state the main idea first; replies lead with good news and answer all queries; order letters are specific and state payment; credit requests need references; refusals thank, explain and keep hope. Sir Ernest Gowers' advice guides tone.

Practice questions

Q1 (MCQ) In AIDA, 'D' stands for:

A. Decision

B. Desire

C. Direction

D. Discount

> **Answer:** B
> **Why:** Attention, Interest, Desire, Action.

Q2 (MCQ) Where should good news be placed in a reply?

A. End

B. Middle

C. Beginning

D. Nowhere

> **Answer:** C
> **Why:** Announce good news first.

Q3 (MSQ) Which are ways to attract attention in a sales letter?

A. Striking statement

B. Quotation

C. Question

D. Threat

> **Answer:** A, B, C
> **Why:** Avoid threats and negatives.

Q4 (T/F) A refusal letter should close all ties with the customer.

> **Answer:** False
> **Why:** It should preserve goodwill.

Q5 (Fill) Gowers advises: if he is rude, be specially _____.

> **Answer:** courteous
> **Why:** Keep courtesy.

Q6 (Short) What should an order letter contain?

> **Answer:** A specific order in the first line, itemised list, and the payment procedure with a cordial close.
> **Why:** No roundabout expressions.

Revision checklist

☐ I can expand AIDA.

☐ I know Gowers' advice.

☐ I can write enquiry and reply letters.

☐ I know order and credit letter rules.

☐ I can write a polite refusal.

Lecture 30: Types of Business Letters Part II

Week 6 · Course book PDF pages 486–503 (printed pages 485–502)

Learning objectives

- Write a collection letter series with a gradually firmer tone.
- Draft a claim (complaint) letter: state the problem, explain, state the adjustment wanted, close cordially.
- Draft an adjustment letter: good news first, active voice, explanation, empathy, appreciation.
- Write a recommendation letter honestly and quote the closing remark on simplicity.

Important definitions

COLLECTION LETTER

A letter, or series of letters, written to recover money owed; tone moves from gentle to firm.

CLAIM / COMPLAINT LETTER

A letter written to correct a wrong and obtain replacement, repair or compensation.

ADJUSTMENT LETTER

The organisation's reply to a claim; conveys the remedy while restoring goodwill.

RECOMMENDATION LETTER

A letter nominating and justifying a person for promotion, awards or recognition, written honestly and confidentially.

EMPATHETIC LANGUAGE

Language that places oneself in the customer's position ("You are right to be disappointed...").

Core concepts

Collection letters

- A **series** (often four) because one letter may be ignored.
- **1st:** gentle reminder; **2nd:** a bit harsh; **3rd:** harsher and indirect; **final:** strong, may be intimidating but still ends cordially.
- Sample final letter: "Despite three reminders we have not received the outstanding amount for 20 photocopiers... You are morally obliged to pay... further delay may force us to hand the matter to legal agencies... Please send the cheque and inform us by telephone by 5 p.m. tomorrow." (deadline set)
- Credit and collection go hand in hand; keep the customer if possible.

Claim letters

- Receiving complaints is good: an opportunity for dialogue, relationship and product improvement and feedback.
- Open with the **problem or the action wanted** (“Please send your service engineer to rectify the technical problems in 20 geysers…”).
- Explain what went wrong without alleging; **appeal to the company’s fair reputation** (“we have always enjoyed your prompt service”).
- State the inconvenience and the adjustment wanted (replacement or refund).
- **Do not blame or shout**; include copies of bills, receipts and documents; suggest remedy.
- Close cordially: “We realise mistakes in ordering and shipping sometimes occur; because we have enjoyed your prompt service, we hope you will send the ACs by …”.
- Example: two employees with confirmed reservations were refused rooms – “would you clarify your room reservation policy for late arrivals?”

Adjustment letters

- Complaints are more valuable than surveys.
- **Open with the good news** (action taken) in **active voice**: “We have sent the new photocopier to your address” – not “has been sent”.
- Explain why things went wrong; give additional information; emphasise the action wanted from the customer.
- **Address the claimant by name.**
- Avoid negative words (trouble, fault, regret, misunderstanding); do not blame the customer or staff; avoid unrealistic promises (“this will never happen again”).
- Use sensitive, empathetic language: “We are really sorry; you are right to be disappointed with the Lumia cell phone” (Gowers: if he convicts you of a mistake, admit it).
- Close with appreciation: “Thanks for writing. Your satisfaction is important to us… our goal is to earn your confidence.”
- Send appreciation notes when a wrong is righted.

Recommendation letters

- Purpose: nominate and justify the merits for promotion, awards or recognition.
- Be **honest**, confidential, not biased; do not exaggerate; avoid vague or ambiguous words.
- Mention if you are writing at someone's suggestion.
- Evaluate communication, organisational, leadership, team and behavioural skills and dynamism.
- Do not include negatives without evidence; keep a copy for your record.
- Closing quotation about letters: “The art of art, the glory of expression and the sunshine of the light of letters is simplicity” (attributed to a famous poet; the transcript gives no name).

Types, classifications and characteristics

Sequence of collection letters

Letter	Tone
First	Gentle, courteous reminder
Second	A little firmer
Third	Harsher, indirect
Final	Strong, deadline, mentions legal action; ends cordially

Claim, adjustment and recommendation letters

Letter	Opening	Key rules
Claim	State the problem / action wanted	No blame; attach documents; request remedy
Adjustment	Good news in active voice	Empathy; address by name; no negatives; thank
Recommendation	State relationship and recommendation	Honest, specific, confidential

Theories, principles, models and contributors

ADMIT MISTAKES — SIR ERNEST GOWERS (CITED AGAIN)

If he convicts you of a mistake, admit it.

Examples and applications

EXAMPLE

Collection letter for 20 photocopiers.

EXAMPLE

Claim letter for 20 faulty geysers.

EXAMPLE

Hotel refused rooms to two employees with confirmed reservations.

EXAMPLE

Adjustment letter replacing a Lumia cell phone with a touch-screen defect.

Comparison tables

Claim versus adjustment letter

Point	Claim	Adjustment
Writer	Customer	Organisation
Opening	Problem or desired action	Good news / action taken
Tone	Polite, firm, not angry	Empathetic, appreciative
Close	Hope for prompt correction	Thanks for writing; promise of service

Important facts for MCQ revision

EXAM TIP

- Collection letters form a series with increasing firmness.
- Open claim letters with the problem or action wanted.
- Do not blame; include documents.
- Adjustment letters open with good news in active voice.
- Address the claimant by name.
- Avoid trouble, fault, regret, misunderstanding and unrealistic promises.
- Complaints are opportunities.
- Keep a copy of recommendation letters.
- Closing quote: simplicity is the glory of expression.

QUIZ-RELATED CONCEPTS (QUIZ PDF PAGE REFERENCES)

Question	Quiz PDF page	Concept tested	Type
W6 Q5	p.22	Collection letters	Fill-in-the-blank
W6 Q11	p.23	Adjustment letters	MSQ
W6 Q12	p.24	Recommendation letters	MSQ
W6 Q15	p.24	Adjustment letters	MSQ

Full question text and answers: Quiz analysis.

Summary

Collection letters grow firmer across a series but keep goodwill. Claim letters state the problem and desired remedy politely with documents; adjustment letters open with the good news in active voice, explain, show empathy, avoid blame and negative words and thank the customer. Recommendation letters must be honest, specific and confidential. Simplicity and cordiality underlie all letters.

Practice questions

Q1 (MCQ) An adjustment letter should open with:

A. An apology for trouble

B. The good news or action taken

C. A threat

D. A query

> **Answer:** B
> **Why:** Good news first, in active voice.

Q2 (MCQ) How many letters typically make up the collection series in the lecture?

A. One

B. Two

C. Four

D. Ten

> **Answer:** C
> **Why:** A final fourth letter is the strongest.

Q3 (MSQ) Which should be avoided in an adjustment letter?

A. Blaming the customer

B. Negative words like trouble

C. Unrealistic promises

D. Thanking the customer

> **Answer:** A, B, C
> **Why:** Thank and empathise.

Q4 (T/F) A claim letter should attach copies of bills and documents.

> **Answer:** True
> **Why:** They support the claim.

Q5 (Fill) Complaints give an organisation a chance to start a _____.

> **Answer:** dialogue
> **Why:** And to improve products.

Q6 (Short) What care is needed in a recommendation letter?

> **Answer:** Be honest, specific, confidential and unbiased; avoid exaggeration and unsupported negatives.
> **Why:** Retain a copy.

Revision checklist

☐ I know the tone progression in collection letters.
☐ I can write a claim letter.
☐ I can write an adjustment letter.
☐ I know recommendation letter rules.
☐ I can list words to avoid.